

Islamic challenges to advertising: a Saudi Arabian perspective

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166

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this study is to synthesize the existing research on Islam and advertising with the perspective of the Salafi authority of Saudi Arabia. This study is an exploration of the impact of the conservative interpretation of Islam on advertising.

Design/methodology/approach – This study critically reviews the literature on advertising in Islam, specifically in the context of the conservative religious Saudi Arabia, Islam and advertising and its connection with the interpretations of the religiously conservative segment of Saudi Arabian society. This systematic review covered 42 studies in Islamic advertising and Salafist/*Hanbali* jurisprudence, ranging from 1980 to 2014. These studies were validated through data triangulation using a meta-synthesis of 39 articles with 5 articles on Salafism and 5 *Hanbali* juristic texts.

Findings – The investigation concludes that there are several factors to be considered when developing advertising messages and content for the conservative segment of Islam. The considerations are as follows: (C1) avoidance of Islamic creedal taboos and displays of immorality; (C2) avoiding usage of musical instruments and taboo entertainment; (C3) women must be dressed appropriately, and gender roles must be in conjunction with Islamic texts; and (C4) avoiding deceptive marketing, defaming competition, and ambiguous transactions. Although there was a general consensus on C1 and C3, few studies discussed C2 and C4. *Hanbali* jurisprudence, the official school of thought in Saudi Arabia, was found to be in agreement with all four considerations. Additionally, the study synthesizes previous studies and contributes more knowledge to the few existing literature on the topic of Islam and advertising. A better understanding of the conservative interpretation of Islam can contribute to scholarship in the field of Islamic marketing.

Research limitations/implications – This paper was limited to the Salafist/Wahhabist interpretation of Islam based on *Hanbali* jurisprudence found in Saudi Arabia. The findings of this paper can be extended and validated through studying the attitudes of Salafists in different regions toward advertising messages and content.

Practical implications – This paper was limited to the Salafist/Wahhabist interpretation of Islam based on *Hanbali* jurisprudence found in Saudi Arabia. The findings of this paper can be extended and validated through studying the attitudes of Salafists in different regions toward advertising messages and content.

Originality/value – This study adds to the limited research on Islamic attitudes and challenges toward advertising in the Middle East. The study reviews existing research and utilizes religious rulings to research the conservative Islamic perspective of advertising.

Keywords Advertisements and promotions to Muslims, Islamic marketing, Islamic law and marketing practices, Selling to Islamic markets

Paper type Case study



1. Introduction

In the past decade, there has been a substantial increase of interest in researching the effects and relationship of advertising and religion. Prior to this, there were only a few studies on the Islamic challenges to advertising in the Gulf Cooperative Council

countries (Rice and Al-Mossawi, 2002). Although more researchers are investigating this field, current studies analyze Islam through a holistic view without recognizing the existence of sectarian and jurisprudent (*Fiqh*) differences of opinion on the interpretation of Islamic law (*Shari'ah*). Therefore, most studies tend toward generalization. However, Saudi Arabia's religious interpretation is considered to be more conservative than other Muslim nations (Rice and Al-Mossawi, 2002). The religious interpretation in the region leads to stricter conservatism among a growing population of consumers who are influenced by the Salafist scholars. This study is an analysis of the Islamic challenges on advertising practices in the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia through investigation of the religious edicts and understanding of the religious establishment in the Kingdom, or *Hanbali* Salafism. This paper argues that an investigation of the religious edicts of Saudi Arabia can contribute to the understanding of the religiously conservative consumer in the Kingdom and its connection to Islamic marketing. Additionally, this study can provide advertising practitioners with the knowledge to develop effective advertisements that achieve the approval of the conservative community. Saudi Arabia's conservative view of Islam, often referred to as "Wahhabism" or Salafism, is established through the verdicts of scholars (*Ulema*) of the country (Lacroix, 2011). Although a plethora of Islamic opinion exists, Saudi Arabia has restricted official verdicts to the Salafist *Hanbali* scholars of the Kingdom. Because of the multiplicity of Islamic interpretations and sects, discussion of all schools of Islamic thought extends beyond the scope of this study. Existing research related to advertising in Saudi Arabia does not address the Salafist *Hanbali* interpretations of Islam, which is the dominant religious school of thought among the Saudi religious authority. It is imperative to consider that there are numerous interpretations of Islamic doctrine and jurisprudence. Although this gives rise to the vast differing of religious opinion in the Muslim world, Saudi Arabia's religious authority strives to establish Salafism as the dominant doctrine of the country as well as preaching it to foreigners through the establishment of Islamic universities within the borders of the Kingdom and in other Muslim states. In terms of jurisprudence (*Fiqh*), Saudi Arabia predominately follows the *Hanbali* school of thought while also considering the opinion of *Maliki*, *Shafi'i* and *Hanafi* schools. Saudi Arabia permits multiplicity of opinions to affect certain laws of the country. However, the predominant interpretation of doctrine is through the Salafi perspective. Salafist scholar, Al-Abbad (2009), noted that the existence of differences of opinion does not validate permissibility of a ruling; however, the obligation is to follow the closest interpretation to the Prophet's generation. Al-Abbad (2009) quotes classical Islamic scholar, Al-Shatibi:

The one who says this returns back to his desires and makes the statement he agrees with as evidence and uses it to satisfy his desires, so he took that statement as a means to follow his desires [...]

While investigating Saudi Arabia's religious authority, the inevitable question of the definition of Salafism arises and how it relates to Saudi Arabia. In addition, the role of the *Hanbali* school of thought should be considered when discussing Saudi Arabia's religious edicts.

Saudi Arabia, often referred to as following the "Wahhabi" interpretation of Islam, named after the followers of Muhammad Ibn Abd al-Wahhab, follows a puritanical interpretation of Islamic texts (Delong-Bas, 2004; Lacroix, 2011). Al-Rasheed (2007)

noted that the Saudi Kingdom was founded on the Salafist school of thought of Muhammad Ibn Abd al-Wahhab. [Bazmul \(2007\)](#) explained that the first King of the third Saudi state, King Abdul-Aziz Al-Saud, declared himself to be a Salafi and founded the country on Salafism, stating:

I am a Salafi and my belief is Salafism that attributes itself to the Qur'an and the Prophetic traditions.

While [Al-Rasheed \(2007\)](#) noted that Wahhabism and Salafism are used interchangeably, the Saudi religious authority denies the existence of Wahhabism ([Bazmul, 2007](#)). Salafist scholar [Al-Fawzan \(2012\)](#) asserted that the former Minister of Interior and Crown Prince Naif Al-Saud emphasized that Saudi Arabia is a Salafist state that adheres to the religious interpretation and theology. [Bazmul \(2007\)](#) described Salafism as an adherence to the Qur'an and Prophetic teachings based on the interpretations of the earliest generations of Islam while rejecting innovations in the religion. [Amghar \(2007\)](#) explained that Salafism was first formalized by Ahmad bin Hanbal during the time of violent sectarianism. According to [Amghar \(2007\)](#), the concept later resurged with Ibn Taymiyya during the invasion of the Mongols. Muhammad Bin Abdul-Wahhab, the ideological father of Saudi Arabia, was influenced by Ibn Taymiyyah's writings and established his teachings based on Salafism. [Gauvain \(2010\)](#) stated that "Wahhabism" or "Salafism" is a conservative interpretation of religious legal practices in Islam and was spread throughout the Middle East through the influence of Saudi Arabia. The objective of this research is to analyze the advertising sphere in the Kingdom in light of the Salafist interpretation of Islam as explained by recognized religious authorities of Saudi Arabia. This investigation begins by proposing the following questions: why is Saudi Arabia a significant region for this study? What is the influence of Salafism in Saudi Arabia? What is the practical and academic application of this study to Islamic marketing and business? The following research question is also posed:

RQ1. What specific factors should practitioners consider while creating advertisements in Saudi Arabia that include the religiously conservative segment of the market?

2. Literature review

Interest in Islamic advertising began to rise in the late 1980s. Researchers focused mainly on the nature of advertising in Islamic countries, such as Saudi Arabia and Malaysia. In the past ten years, more research has been conducted into Islamic marketing with dedicated journals focused on discussing various issues related to Islam and marketing ([Wilson, 2012](#)). Earlier studies composed of empirical research based on Qur'anic and Prophetic texts ([Luqmani et al., 1989](#)). Numerous studies constituted content analyses of current advertising messages and campaigns in Muslim countries with some contrasting ads to American or British campaigns ([Kalliny, 2010](#)). [Al-Makaty et al. \(1996\)](#) explained in their study that Islam permits advertising with regulations. [Rice and Al-Mossawi \(2002\)](#) classified the target audience of Islamic marketing as Muslims without the consideration of their juristic views or theological adherence. Likewise, much of the focus on Islamic challenges was generalized to the Muslim audience. [Wilson \(2012\)](#) argued that advertising practitioners must have a knowledge of Islamic ethics, values and religious rulings when considering Middle Eastern markets. [Luqmani et al. \(1989\)](#) established that ignoring the influence of religion, specifically

Islam, on advertising can alienate a significant portion of the population that adheres to the theology. [Fam et al. \(2004\)](#) emphasized that an alienated segment of the population will contribute to a negative brand perception. The alienated segment can also influence societal perception and negatively affect consumer attitudes ([Michell and Al-Mossawi, 1999](#)). [Luqmani et al. \(1989\)](#) also noted that religious authorities play a strong role in brand perception among the conservative segment of the population. Current studies consider the influence of Islam on advertising practices, yet they do not delve into the influence of Salafism, as a theology, and Hanbalism, as jurisprudence, in Saudi Arabia.

2.1 Lucrative advertising opportunities in Saudi Arabia

Saudi Arabia's growing economy has opened doors to foreign investment into the traditionally conservative Kingdom ([Abdul Cader, 2012](#)). Only three decades ago, Saudi Arabia was not a player in the international market. The advertising and promotion industries in Saudi Arabia were barren ([Erdem and Tuncalp, 1998](#)). A handful of locally owned advertising companies operated in the Kingdom, producing few billboards and newspaper advertisements. In 2000, the Saudi Arabian Government made foreign direct investment easier for multinational corporations ([Usa, 2009](#)). This creation of investment opportunities led to the influx of foreign companies into Saudi Arabia. [Smith \(2008\)](#) observed that between 2005 and 2006, there has been a 51 per cent rise in foreign investment into the country amounting to an estimated US\$214 billion.

The change in demographics from an older population to a younger consumer market is a major factor in encouraging foreign firms in investing in Saudi Arabia ([Abdul Cader, 2012](#)). [Earth Trends \(2007\)](#) reported that 42 per cent of the Saudi population is below the age of 15 years, while 60 per cent is under 18 years of age. The young consumer market is more sustainable than the older consumers ([Gunter and Furnham, 1998](#)). Considering that the Saudi demographic consists of a larger population of youth, companies can capitalize through effective marketing targeted toward the youth. The [Business Monitor International \(2014\)](#) indicated that the highest percentage of retail revenue is attained through the 15-35 years' age range. [Assad \(2006\)](#) reported a rise in consumerism in Saudi Arabia because of the increase in disposable income. [Assad \(2007\)](#) argued that in addition to the introduction of television and the Internet, marketing strategies and manipulative advertising have spread consumerism among Saudis. The increased income per capita from the oil wealth allowed younger Saudis to spend more of their earnings in the retail industry. The growing consumerism in Saudi Arabia, coupled with rising ease of entry, provides international firms with an opportunity to penetrate the Saudi market, provided that caution is taken when dealing with the religious authority.

Since the early 1980s, there was a greater need for advertising companies in Saudi Arabia. More advertising practitioners from around the world began to flood into the country ([Erdem and Tuncalp, 1998](#)). According to [Katib and Manair's \(1991\)](#) study of advertising agencies in Saudi Arabia, the majority of companies were small businesses, while identifying only two large organizations that served all the regions of the country. Since then, the number of advertising agencies has increased, with many foreign advertising companies joint-venturing with local Saudi firms ([Erdem and Tuncalp, 1998](#)). [Luqmani et al. \(1989\)](#) stated that there are no official regulatory bodies for monitoring advertisements. The Ministry of Commerce and Ministry of Information set compliance guidelines, which are the formal channels for handling violations. The

2.2 *Salafism and Hanbalism*

Salafism is an Islamic methodology, or theology, that requires Muslims to adhere to the understanding of the earliest generation of Islam, known as the *Salaf* (Lauziere, 2010; Lacroix, 2011; Wiktorowicz, 2006; and Duderija, 2010). Wiktorowicz (2006) explained that Salafism postulates unified principles and methodology for understanding Islamic creed, jurisprudence and contemporary issues. Bazmul (2007) noted that the ideology of Salafism is defined as a methodology of understanding Islamic texts as opposed to separate set of creed orthodox Islam. He stresses that Salafism is in actuality the purest form of orthodoxy. Popularly referred to as “Wahhabism”, Salafism is a puritanical theology (Duderija, 2010). It is defined as the purest way of Islamic life based on the understanding of the best generations of Muslims (Bazmul, 2007). Lauziere (2010) noted that, although there has been much debate regarding the historical usage of the term, the existence and attribution of Salafism has been firmly established in historical texts. He further asserted that poor scholarship and uncertainties have clouded research and led to numerous political definitions of Salafism. According to Lacroix (2011), Salafism is identified by its conservatism in interpreting religious texts. Referring to the historical accounts of the Islamic historian, Kathir (2000), Lauziere (2010) argued that Salafism and Hanbalism were interchangeable terms. Salafist scholar Al-Madkhali (2004) asserted that Hanbalism and Salafism have no creedal differences. Because of this, Islamic law is derived based on jurisprudent principles (*Usul*). Aba Al-Khail (2004) cited four principles in deriving Islamic rulings: the Qur’an, the Prophetic traditions, consensus of opinions and analogy. The interpretations of the first two sources differed within schools of thought and the level of reliance on latter source differs within the four *Sunni* schools of thought.

A codified Salafist school of jurisprudence does not exist. However, Salafists rely on the four schools of jurisprudence with denunciation of blindly following religious opinions (Al-Abbas, 2010). Salafist scholar Al-Abbas (2010) explained that this requires Muslims to carefully analyze religious opinions based on the understanding of the earliest generations of Muslims regarding the Islamic texts. Because of this, religious opinion and verdicts are subjected to the process of verification (*Tajreeh*). The process of verification between schools of jurisprudence and religious text, also referred to as comparative jurisprudence, is a common factor in the Salafist theology. However, the most common verification of juristic opinions occurred within a single school (*Madhhab*). For example, verification of the multiple opinions of Imam Ahmad bin Hanbal within the *Hanbali* school of thought. This is the reason that it is possible to adhere to Salafism and follow one of the prominent schools of thought. The twelfth century Islamic scholar Al-Dhahabi recorded numerous instances in his *Siyar A’lam An-Nubala*, where jurists of the *Hanafi*, *Hanbali*, *Shafi’i*, or *Maliki* schools were also Salafists. This duality of thought is also seen in important works of jurists within the schools of thought, such as in *Tabaqat Al-Fuqaha Al-Shafi’iyah* and *Tabaqat Al-Hanabilah* (Lauziere, 2010). Although many of the Salafist scholars of Saudi Arabia follow the *Hanbali* school of thought, it is not uncommon to find edicts from the *Maliki* or *Shafi’i* schools given precedence because of the process of verification between schools. Research on Islamic advertising and marketing generalize Islamic law

(*Shari'ah*) to define challenges (Fam *et al.*, 2004; Luqmani *et al.*, 1989; Olayan and Karande, 2000).

2.3 Religious influence on Saudi Arabian society and government

According to Al-Dahlawi (1996), the four prominent schools of *Sunni* Islamic thought (*Madhahib*) spread and became dominant in certain areas because of the strength of religious and political influence in certain regions. He argued that the *Maliki* school dominated the North African region of the Muslim world, whereas the *Shafi'i* school became prominent in the Levant, Yemen and South-East Asia. The *Hanafi* school became the prevalent school of thought in South Asia, whereas the *Hanbali* school took official legal precedence in Gulf region and Iraq. Saudi Arabia's governance of Islamic law (*Shari'ah*) extends to all legislation in the Kingdom (Luqmani *et al.*, 1989). Luqmani *et al.* (1989) did not consider the influence of Salafist Hanbalism on Saudi Arabia's interpretation of Islamic law. The Saudi Government was traditionally based on religious authority consisting of a group of Islamic scholars and a governing body composed of ministers and the Shura council, who are responsible for the business laws governing the country (Abdul Cader, 2012). The religious authority is divided into two committees:

- (1) the Permanent Committee for Islamic Research and Religious Edicts; and
- (2) the Council of Senior Scholars.

These two groups are responsible for the interpretation of religious issues in the country. Although these two religious bodies are responsible for the issuance of religious edicts (*fatwas*), other scholars play a role in developing religious opinion in the Kingdom. After several controversial rulings were issued by some Saudi clerics, King Abdullah Al-Saud barred non-appointed clerics from issuing any rulings (Al-Arabiya, 2010a). The royal decree stated that only the scholars holding official religious positions and those they appoint can issue public rulings. This decree is enforced by the Ministry of Interior, Ministry of Justice and Ministry of Islamic Affairs. The Permanent Committee for Islamic Research and Religious Edicts was established by Royal Decree 137/1 as the official committee responsible for the issuance of religious rulings. Although members of the Council of Senior Scholars issue rulings on an individual basis, the rulings issued by the Permanent Committee for Islamic Research and Religious Edicts are the official stance of the religious authority. The Permanent Committee for Islamic Research and Religious Edicts is composed of four members headed by the Grand Mufti of Saudi Arabia. The members of this organization were selected from the 21-member Council of Senior Scholars. Bazmul (2007) indicated that the creation of the Permanent Committee for Islamic Research and Religious Edicts and the Council of Senior Scholars was established as a result of the adherence to the *Salafi* methodology of Saudi Arabia.

Saudi Arabia's culture is based on Saudi tradition and religious interpretation (Abdul Cader, 2012). The effects of Salafism in Saudi Arabia are strongly reflected in Saudi cultural traditions, such as the face veil and black cloaks for women (*Abayat*). Nassif and Gunter (2008) concluded that there is a visible difference in the representation of women in the Gulf and Western countries. They found that in Saudi advertisements, the majority of representations of women were in the home (69 per cent). They concluded that this was a result of the Islamic influence in Saudi Arabia. Bazmul (2007) stated that

the effects of Salafism in Saudi Arabia can be seen from three aspects: application of Islamic legislation, Islamic punishments and being proactive in ordaining the good and forbidding the evil. This influence extends to all of the mosques in the Kingdom under the patronage of the Ministry of Islamic Affairs, chaired by Salafist scholar Saleh Al-Sheikh. The distribution of Islamic books, classes and sermons are governed and monitored by the Ministry who ensure that distributed material is in agreement with Salafism. In addition, the required Islamic courses in the education system are dictated through the Salafist teachings of Muhammad Bin Abdul-Wahhab and the scholars of Saudi Arabia. Despite this prominent influence of conservative religious opinion, current studies do not focus on jurisprudential interpretations.

Few of the studies focused on the influence of juristic differences in business and marketing. The influence of Salafism and Hanbalism in Saudi Arabia is significant. The Kingdom has witnessed many incidents that changed governmental, commercial and political policies because of the influence of Salafism. For instance, several Salafist students at the Islamic University of Madinah set out around the city to destroy any images or photographs in 1965 (Al-Huzaymi, 2012). This incident, known as “the breaking of the pictures” (*Taksir Al-Suwar*), led to the creation of an organization known as the JSM (*Jama’a Al-Salafiyyah Al-Muhtasiba*) with the approval of the former Mufti of Saudi Arabia, Abdul-Aziz Bin Baz. The JSM opposed any forms of interpretation deemed impermissible by the religious authority of Saudi Arabia. Al-Huzaymi (2012), a former member of the radicalized faction of the group known as the Brothers (*Ikhwan*), described some of the strategies used by the members of the JSM to eradicate what they considered opposition to Islam. The JSM would set-up a store to sell Islamic tapes beside music stores that would play music to attract customers. The JSM would play tapes of Qur’anic recitation to force music store owners to stop playing their music. Out of guilt, potential customers would avoid purchasing music tapes from these stores, which would eventually cause the store owners to close down (Al-Huzaymi, 2012).

Such tactics were soon replicated in other areas of Saudi Arabia through the JSM and conservatives who were not affiliated with the group. The effects of this strategy are still seen today in areas where Islamic bookstores and Islamic media outlets are found. Al-Khchiban (2009) argued that the Saudi society was not entirely changed because of Juhayman’s 1979 seizure on the Grand Mosque; rather, the society was inevitably headed in that direction. The Grand Mosque seizure still has a major impact on the religious orientation of the Saudi society (Al-Hamad, 2009). The legitimization of the JSM, whose purpose was to establish religious practices, was the precursor to the current activities of the Organization for the Promotion of Virtue and Prevention of Vice (*Al-Haia Al Amr bil Ma’ruf wa Al-Nahi ‘an Al-Munkar*). The religious police (*Mutawa’*) originated by the order of King Abdul-Aziz Al-Saud with the primary objective of preventing any immoral activities in the society (Al-Abbad, 2009). Since the collapse of the JSM, the religious police took on more roles in the society. One aspect of their duties is to monitor print and media advertisements for any activity that violates Islamic rules (Cook, 2010).

2.4 Religion, culture and advertising in Saudi Arabia

The standardization versus customization debate produced numerous studies over several decades (Agrawal, 1995). Advertising practitioners are faced with the decision to standardize, customize or follow a contingency in their advertising messages. Agrawal

(1995) found that practitioners tended to follow standardization, whereas academics favored customization. Okazaki *et al.* (2006) argued that standardization contributes more to a firm's profitability and aids overall performance. This study considered two culturally different markets in Japan and the USA. However, they considered only three factors that affect the firm's level of advertising: the external environment, strategy and internal organization orientation. The study also concluded that the size of the firm affects its ability to standardize; however, international experience could not be shown to have any effects. Although this study focuses on two culturally diverse markets, it does not consider religious influence on advertising. It should be considered that cognitive information processing can occur through active or inactive thought persuasion (Bryant, 2008). Naseri and Tamam (2012) argued that persuasion in advertising can occur through either of these two means. While considering these perspectives in establishing effective advertising, it is imperative to ensure that the message is not hindered by religious and cultural factors. Systematic persuasion states that subjects actively process information through cognitive thought, whereas heuristic persuasion is dependent on variables in different scenarios with less emphasis on detailed processing of the message (Chaiken, 1980). In either case, the influence of religion and culture subjects the message of the advertisement to the affiliation process (Benoit and Benoit, 2008). Islam has a strong influence in the cognitive decision-making process when faced with advertising (Fam *et al.*, 2004). Decades of research document the influence and effect of religion on consumer behavior (Luqmani *et al.*, 1989; Michell and Al-Mossawi, 1999; Birch *et al.*, 2001). Because of this, global standardization of advertising is not a feasible strategy in Saudi Arabia.

Luqmani *et al.* (1989) asserted that religion takes precedence over culture regarding its influence on advertising in Saudi Arabia. Engle *et al.* (2011) argued that the transformation of the marketing ecosystem through technological advances poses a new challenge in competition between companies. The differences in cultural and religious perceptions of young Saudi consumers pose a greater challenge to multinational firms seeking to compete in Saudi Arabia. Roth (1995) concluded that culture and religion has a significant impact on global brand imaging and marketing practices. The implications of this study are evident in international marketing campaigns practiced by successful multinational enterprises. The decision whether to globalize or customize advertising campaigns is affected by numerous factors such as culture and religion (Harris, 1994). Customization of advertising campaigns requires companies to understand the culture and the religion that they desire to operate in. Standardization of advertising campaigns may affect the effectiveness of the advertisement if the culture or religion opposes the campaigns (Harris, 1994).

Luqmani *et al.* (1989) stated that the majority of study in advertising regulation overlooks the Middle East region, particularly Saudi Arabia. While making key observations on advertising regulations in Saudi Arabia, Luqmani *et al.* (1989) did not deeply investigate the conservative religious background of Saudi Arabia. Of the external factors that influence advertising, religion and culture are the most sensitive. Kalliny (2010) concluded that some aspects of Arab culture are more influenced by religion than in America. In Saudi Arabia, religion has a stronger influence than the culture, and this can be seen by the change in cultural sensitivity in advertising since Luqmani *et al.*'s study in 1989. Tuncalp (1992) noted that Saudi Arabia's advertising industry was still in infancy. Almost 20 years later, certain factors Tuncalp mentioned

as important mediums of advertising, such as cinema and advertising on government radio stations, are still not available in Saudi Arabia. While Saudi society became more open to movies, the conservative segment of the country resisted and prevented cinemas from being opened in Saudi Arabia, leading to protests from both sides. This raises an important concern for advertising practitioners about the role of religious conservatives in Saudi Arabia's marketing field. [Tuncalp \(1992\)](#) concluded that the majority of advertisements produced in Saudi Arabia are through print media. Advances in mobile technology have enabled advertising companies to reach a greater segment of the population. Under the premise of religious and cultural conflicts, Saudi Arabia threatened to ban mobile applications and social media ([Howard et al., 2011](#)).

Although culture remains a challenge to marketing campaigns of multinational firms in Saudi Arabia, the religious framework is a major factor that contributes to the difficulty of employing common marketing practices in the country. [Assad \(2006\)](#) asserted that a major factor that led to the rise in Saudi consumerism is the emulation of the Western society and its impact on the local culture. This indicates a change in cultural norms between the older and younger population in Saudi because of the exposure to other traditions. Although culture can undergo transformations as the dynamics of the population changes, religion essentially remains the same ([Abdul Cader, 2012](#)). [Kacen and Lee \(2002\)](#) explained that culture moderates buyer behavior. However, [Assad \(2006\)](#) noted that culture can change because of outside influences. While traditions may be influenced by foreign interferences, Salafism entails that the fundamental rulings of the religion remain the same and continue to dictate Islamic behavior in the Kingdom ([Bazmul, 2007](#)). [Luqmani et al. \(1989\)](#) asserted that religion remains a constant barrier to advertising in Saudi Arabia. The study conducted by [Luqmani et al. \(1989\)](#) is instrumental in establishing the basis Islam's influence on advertising in Saudi Arabia. They determined three Qur'anic messages that influence advertising messages:

- (1) Taboos (*Haram*): alcohol, lotteries, deceptive advertising, depiction of idols and non-Islamic portrayal of women.
- (2) Islamic activities: respecting Islamic duties such as prayer times.
- (3) Being thankful for blessings of God (*Allah*).

[Rice and Al-Mossawi's \(2002\)](#) study focused on gender roles in advertising in Islam. They noted that because of religious interpretations, there is a variation in the roles of women in advertising across the Muslim world. The current studies on Islam and advertising give precedence to positive actions, such as showing family values, as opposed to challenges, such as depiction of sins ([Luqmani et al., 1989](#); [Rice and Al-Mossawi, 2002](#); [Kalliny, 2010](#); [Fam et al., 2004](#)). The predominant scholarly discussion of Islamic challenges of advertising focuses on gender roles ([Rice, 2004](#); [Rice and Al-Mossawi, \(2002\)](#); [Luqmani et al., 1989](#); [Nassif, 2008](#); [Kalliny, 2010](#); [Olayan, 2013](#)) and display of immorality ([Alserhan and Alserhan, 2012](#); [AlAbdali, 2009](#); [Tuncalp, 1992](#)).

3. Methods

A systematic review was used to identify relevant studies through Business Source Complete (Ebsco), ABI/INFORM complete, Emerald, Proquest, JSTOR, Elsevier and Google Scholar databases. Initially, articles were selected if the following key words

were found in the title or abstract: “Islam” and “marketing” or “advertising”; “Islamic marketing”; “Islamic advertising”; “Salafism”; and “marketing” or “advertising”; “Salafism”; “Saudi Arabia”; and “marketing” or “advertising”; “Hanbalism”; or “marketing” or “advertising” and “Hanbalism”. Variants of the terms “Salafism” and “Hanbalism” were used to enhance the search radius. Filters were created to limit the search index to English articles published in peer-reviewed journals or books between 1980 and 2014. The last search was conducted on March 20, 2014. These criteria identified 612 articles and books. The study involved a two-tier selection process. The first tier that utilized a two-step process was used in the selection of relevant articles. The first step screened abstracts to identify studies related to advertising and marketing ($n = 190$). The second step involved examination of the full-text to identify challenges to marketing and advertising based on Islamic principles ($n = 89$). Articles were selected if they:

- analyzed Islamic challenges in relation to marketing principles;
- measured advertising strategies against Islamic ethics and values; and
- discussed the role of Islam in advertising or marketing.

The second exclusion phase was based on categorizing content into positive attributes ($n = 52$), which are regarded as praiseworthy advertising elements, and negative attributes ($n = 37$), which are regarded as challenges and barriers. The second tier was a screening of the title and abstracts to identify articles that related to the theology and jurisprudence of Salafism and Hanbalism ($n = 61$). The full-text was analyzed for discussion on jurisprudence relatable to marketing and advertising ($n = 5$).

The information collected from the full-text articles included the following:

- references to Qur’anic and Prophetic texts;
- barriers and challenges to marketing and advertising;
- ethical Islamic principles;
- examples and case studies related to Islamic marketing and its challenges; and
- *Hanbali*/Salafist jurisprudence.

The final sample selection that was sufficiently valid for the research question (*RQ1*) was combined from Tiers 1 and 2 ($n = 42$). A meta-synthesis was conducted on these articles to derive four considerations that address the research question. Transferability of the articles was evaluated against the research question. Quality assessment of the results based on the *Salafi* theology and *Hanbali* jurisprudence was validated through triangulation of recurrent themes with established *Hanbali* jurisprudence reference collections: *Al-Mughni* of Ibn Qudamah; *Al-Furu’* of Ibn Muflih; *Majmu’ Al-Fatawa* of Ibn Taimiah; *Fatawa Al-Lajnah Al-Da’imah*; *Majmu’a* of Al-Sa’di; *Fatawa* of Ibn Al-Uthaimin. Figure 1 depicts the process of selection and analysis, and Figure 2 displays the validation process.

4. Results and discussion

Forty-two studies were identified for use in this review. Thirty-seven of these studies examined Islamic principles in relation to the challenges of marketing and advertising (88.1 per cent). Twenty-nine studies related to the Islamic challenges of marketing and

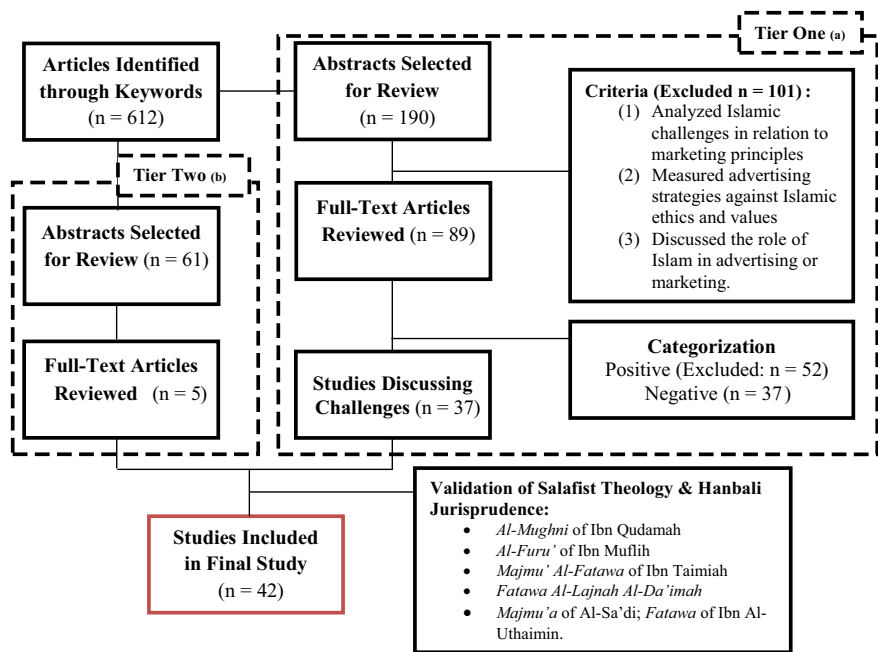


Figure 1.
Process of selection
and analysis

Notes: (a) Critical research on Islamic challenges to advertising review process;
(b) Critical review of Salafist and Hanbali jurisprudent process

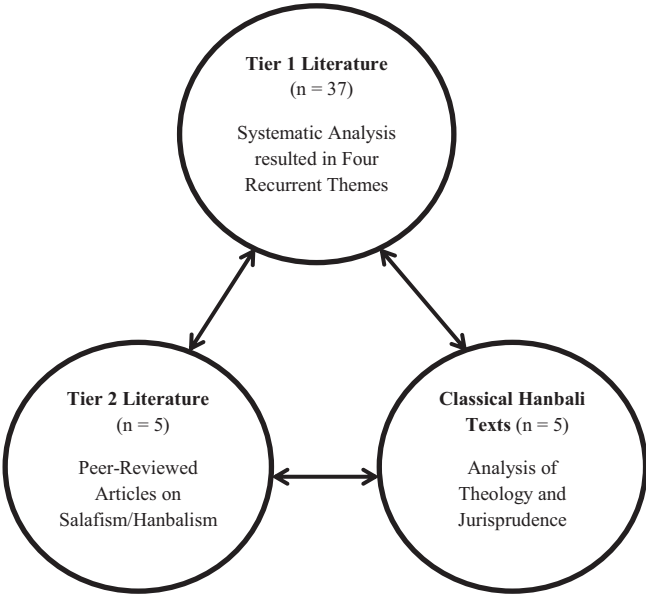


Figure 2.
Data triangulation

advertising were conducted in the past ten years (78.3 per cent), showing that there has been an increase of 150 per cent in the number of papers published in the past ten years, with a steady increase since 2011. There has been a greater effort from researchers in studying Islamic marketing (Wilson, 2012). Eight of these papers specified the Saudi Arabian segment (27.5 per cent), whereas four focused on the Islamic challenges in Saudi Arabia (13.7 per cent). No study examined the Salafist theology or *Hanbali* jurisprudence in relation to Islamic marketing in Saudi Arabia. Five of the studies from Tier 2 provided insights into Salafist theology and *Hanbali* jurisprudence that can be used for Islamic marketing, but did not specifically address advertising or marketing.

A meta-synthesis conducted based on the recurring themes found in the sample studies netted four general categories or considerations (Table I). The first consideration (C1) encompassed themes related to Islamic creed and religious taboos or sins. The second consideration (C2) included entertainment taboos in the conservative segment, specifically music. The third consideration (C3) related to themes of appropriate dress for women and gender roles. The fourth consideration (C4) concerned marketing activities and competitive strategies that are regulated by Islamic law (*Shari'ah*). Thirty-four studies concluded that immoral behavior, non-Islamic themes and creedal offenses (C1) pose a severe challenge to marketing (91.8 per cent). Four studies discussed the taboo of musical entertainment in advertising (C2) as a threat to marketing in Islamic countries (10.8 per cent). Sixteen studies categorized gender roles and the

Sample studies	N	(%)
Total	37	
C1	34	91.8
Depict polytheism or disbelief in Islam	32	86.4
Portray or promote immorality, nudity, lewd behavior	34	91.8
Display the cross, star of David, Hindu statues, Buddha	5	13.5
Use profane language or use obscenities	28	75.6
Promote secular ideologies	3	8.01
C2	4	10.8
Use background music in advertising	3	8.01
Show music bands or concerts	1	2.07
Offensive music	1	2.07
C3	16	43.2
Show inappropriately dressed women	15	40.5
Women must be covered, except face and hands	12	32.4
Women must be fully covered	2	5.04
Women shown outside the house must wear black Abaya	1	2.07
Women should not be shown working jobs that are taboo for women	2	5.04
C4	12	32.4
Defaming individuals, companies, competitors	11	29.7
Deceptive marketing and advertising	8	21.6
False advertising	3	8.01
Ambiguous transactions	5	13.5

Table I.
Metasynthesis of
results

appearance of women (C3) as a challenge (43.2 per cent). Twelve studies discussed deceptive marketing and competitive foul play (C4) as an Islamic barrier to marketing (32.4 per cent).

Religious taboos (*Muharamat*) are strictly forbidden in advertising messages in Saudi Arabia. [Luqmani et al. \(1989\)](#) noted that encouraging or depicting immoral behavior, such as consumption of alcohol, is a punishable offence in Saudi Arabia. Sins in Islam are classified into major and minor offenses. Muhammad bin Abdul-Wahhab explained the definition of a major sin as any act that the Qur'an and Prophetic traditions promise a punishment in the afterlife, a legal punishment, a curse or the anger of Allah. The worst of these sins is any act or display of polytheism (*Shirk*). This is established in Chapter 4, Verse 48:

Indeed, Allah does not forgive association with Him, but He forgives what is less than that for whom He wills. And he who associates others with Allah has certainly fabricated a tremendous sin.

Former Grand Mufti of Saudi Arabia, Abdul-Aziz bin Baz, explained that polytheism in any form removes a person from Islam, unlike other sins. [Luqmani et al.'s \(1989\)](#) first Qur'anic injunction can be divided into two sub-categories: creedal taboos and sins. This division is justified through the severity of creedal violations over sins. Abdul-Aziz bin Baz explained that unlike creedal issues, major sins do not expel a person from Islam. [Mallia \(2009\)](#) reported that depiction of religion in advertising has evolved to include portrayals of God, angels, prophets and devils. Such depiction of polytheism and divinity in advertising messages are considered as a serious religious violation in Saudi Arabia. The offensive nature of such acts can destroy a company's brand image and lead to a ban or a boycott. [Alashban et al. \(2002\)](#) noted that Nike has been boycotted by some Saudi consumers because of the attachment of the brand name to a Greek deity. Notable Salafist scholar, [Al-Uthaymin \(2004\)](#), called for a boycott of products with names of deities, although he excused sellers who may not know the meanings of these words in the English language. [Rice and Al-Mossawi \(2002\)](#) cited the example of ABB's advertising attempts in Bahrain. The ABB logo had appeared to create the image of a cross in the white background of the red-lettered text. Because of this, ABB could not advertise using this version of their logo.

The effect of mass boycott after rallied support from conservatives in Saudi Arabia can be seen in [Jensen's \(2008\)](#) study on the consequences of the Danish cartoons. Danish products were removed from shelves of Saudi stores, which led to Arla publishing advertisements in Saudi newspapers disassociating itself from the controversy ([Jensen, 2008](#)). The company lost approximately US\$51.7 million after a month of the Middle Eastern boycott, which began in Saudi Arabia. Although the boycott was not initiated by the Saudi Government, religious conservatives encouraged consumers to take a stance against Arla ([Jensen, 2008](#)). While Arla was not at fault for the Danish cartoons, the effects of ignoring religious conservatism in Saudi Arabia can be seen from this scenario. Practitioners must take this element into consideration when developing their marketing campaign for Saudi Arabia. Based on this, the following consideration is proposed:

- C1. To avoid negative brand image in Saudi Arabia and prevent legal action, advertising messages must not offend or violate Islamic creed.

Cook (2010) discussed the *Hanbali* perspective on violation of Islamic creed and open display of immorality. Citing Salafist *Hanbali* ideologues, such as Abu Bakr Al-Khallal and Al-Marrudhi, he stated that public displays of immorality or offending the Islamic creed should be prevented by the state, and if permitted by the authority, it should be carried out by every able Muslim. This narrative is oft-repeated in *Hanbali* books of jurisprudence (Al-Abbad, 2009). The results of the meta-synthesis showed agreement (91.8 per cent). Provocative advertising messages cannot be shown in Saudi Arabia and can lead to boycott, as Jensen (2008) described in his study. Of the five studies on *Hanbali* jurisprudence, all concluded prohibition of displaying immorality and creedal violations.

Depiction of major and minor sins in advertising messages are monitored by the Committee for the Promotion of Virtue and Prevention of Vice, an act known as *Hisba* in Islamic doctrine (Al-Abbad, 2009; Bazmul, 2007). The sale of alcoholic beverages and pork products are strictly forbidden in Saudi Arabia. Infractions of this regulation are rare in Saudi Arabia, which indicates that companies are generally compliant to taboos of Islamic law. However, some components of Salafist *Hanbali* interpretation of Islamic law are overlooked, such as utilization of background music in television commercials. Prior studies do not mention the taboo of music in Saudi Arabia. Kellaris and Cox (1989) noted that the effect of background music on consumer behavior is controversial. Studies conducted on background music have shown contradictory results. Although the effects of music on consumer behavior are disputed, practitioners have since utilized background music in television commercials. While the debate on music has been ongoing in the Muslim world, Salafist scholars in Saudi Arabia declared music to be an Islamic taboo. Salafist clerics relied on Prophetic traditions found in Al-Bukhari's compilation of traditions and on classic interpretations of the Qur'an, such as Ibn Kathir and Al-Qurtubi. Opponents to this position, such as Adel Al-Kalbani, assert that no authentic evidence exist to prohibit music in Islam (Al-Arabiya, 2010a). In edict 1900, the religious authority stated:

[...] the Muslim must abandon singing and music and not to listen to them.

Conservative Muslims are advised by Salafist scholars to avoid going to places where music is present, such as events, festivals and even parties (Al-Duwaish, 2010). While music is not banned in Saudi Arabia, there is a high level of sensitivity among the conservative segment of the society toward music. For instance, former *Imam* of the Grand Mosque in Mecca, Adil Al-Kalbani, was removed from his position because of his controversial ruling that music with decent lyrics is permissible in Islam. This controversial statement sparked outrage in the conservative segment of Saudi Arabia, prompting many highly regarded Salafist scholars to denounce Adil Al-Kalbani's edict (Al-Arabiya, 2010a). Otterbeck (2012) argued that the public opinion of music in Saudi Arabia has changed among metropolitan segments of society, although religious conservatives still oppose the spread of music in the country and continue to influence opinion. Islamic television channels bypass the challenge through use of vocals without any musical instruments. The following consideration is proposed:

- C2. Companies can reach the conservative segment of the population through use of vocals without utilizing musical instruments.

Hanbali jurists, namely, Ibn Taimiah, Ibn Qudamah, Ibn Rajab and Al-Zarkhashi, stated that there is scholarly consensus among *Hanbali* jurists against music. Cook (2010) asserted these rulings in his study on *Hanbali* Salafist doctrine. Otterbeck (2012), Akhter *et al.* (2011) and Rice and Al-Mossawi (2002) all noted the opposition of conservatives toward background music in advertising. This theme is unique to the conservative market and is not addressed in the other studies (89.2 per cent). Contemporary conservative Salafist scholars in Saudi Arabia, such as the Permanent Committee of Scholars, took a firm stance against music and advised Muslims to shun and avoid entertainment involving music (Al-Duwaish, 2010). Wilson and Liu (2011) noted that offensive music should be avoided for the general Muslim market. Conservatives, however, oppose musical instruments, as they deemed it prohibited (Al-Qahtani, 2012). However, this view is not shared in all theological views. Al-Qaradawi's opposition to this ruling has shown effects in some Saudi religious circles (Otterbeck, 2012). According to Otterbeck (2012), Al-Qaradawi's views on the permissibility of music are the more popular opinion in the Muslim world.

The role of women in television advertisements is becoming more acceptable in the Western world (Zimmerman and Dahlberg, 2008). The Islamic world differs in portrayal of women in advertising with Saudi Arabia being the most conservative of the Muslim world. The role of women in Saudi Arabia is a sensitive religious and cultural issue (Rice and Al-Mossawi, 2002). Luqmani *et al.* (1989) provided an example of the role of women in cosmetic advertisements. Their suggestion was to refrain from using sensual themes in the role of women. Muslims rely on a Qur'anic order for women to cover:

And tell the believing women to lower their gaze and guard their private parts and not expose their adornment except what is apparent and to wrap their veils over their chests and not expose their adornment [...]

Although a number of interpretations exist of this verse, the most widely accepted in the Muslim world is that a woman must cover her body except her face and hands. However, the stricter interpretation includes the face veil (Rice and Al-Mossawi, 2002). The latter opinion is the choice of the Salafist scholars of Saudi Arabia. While teaching at the Islamic University of Madinah, contemporary Salafist *Hadith* scholar Muhammad Nasiruddin Al-Albani chose the former opinion. His opinion sparked controversy among Saudi Salafist scholars, prompting a response from prominent Salafist scholar Hamood Al-Tuwayjiri. The face veil is also regarded as a tradition among Saudi women, creating difficulty for advertising practitioners to portray Saudi women in ads. Al-Makaty *et al.* (1996) observed that Saudi advertisements often feature women who are veiled, but show their hands and faces. Advertisements showing women inside the house must still observe the dress code, and when advertisements show women outside of the house, they must be wearing the traditional black cloak (*Abayat*).

Al-Olayan and Karande (2000) found many differences in the portrayal of women in Saudi ads and other Middle Eastern ads. Saudi Arabia was more conservative in depiction of women than other Muslim countries in the Middle East. Nassif and Gunter (2008) concluded that women were portrayed more often in domestic roles in Saudi Arabia than in Britain. They argued that the topic of women in advertising is still a sensitive issue in Saudi Arabia. It is imperative that the women are not depicted in any sexual manner, shown intermingling with unrelated males or performing jobs outside of culturally accepted roles. Former chief of the religious police, Ahmad Al-Ghamdi,

created outrage when he announced that Islam permits intermingling of sexes (*Ikhtilat*). Al-Ghamdi's remarks led to protests outside his house, which forced government officials to crack down harder on the encouragement of intermingling (Al-Sulami, 2010). Nassif and Gunter's (2008) study noted that advertisements in Saudi Arabia tended to depict women in more domestic role than occupational roles. Women are far less represented in advertising than male counterparts in Saudi Arabia (Razzouk and Al-Khatib, 1993). Based on these notions, the following consideration is proposed:

- C3. Companies should ensure that their advertisements show women who are dressed modestly, showing only their hands and faces inside the home. Women shown outside the home should be wearing the black cloak (*Abayat*) and not shown intermingling with unrelated males or performing taboo jobs for women, such as driving or field engineering.

Islamic law outlines corporate behavior in relation to competition. Defaming competition is a violation of Islamic etiquette and considered reprehensible behavior. Salafist scholars in Saudi Arabia argued that competitive behavior must not create a damaging atmosphere because it is in violation to Qur'anic injunction:

And cooperate with one another in piety and righteousness, and do not cooperate upon sin and transgression [...]

Cooperation in righteousness also entails etiquette in competition between businesses (Al-Abbad, 2009). Islamic values emphasize on brotherhood between Muslims, which is the premise of working together as a community rather than individualistically. Rice and Al-Mossawi (2002) noted that exaggeration and deception are considered offensive in Saudi Arabia. Deceptive marketing tactics are also considered a violation of Islamic law (Luqmani *et al.*, 1989; Rice and Al-Mossawi, 2002). This indicates that advertising messages must not mislead any segments of the society. Salafist scholars quote the Prophetic tradition:

Whoever deceives is not from us.

Deception in advertising is taken very seriously in Islam and can lead to legal action taken against companies. This type of behavior in advertising messages can sow distrust between the consumer and the company (Darke and Ritchie, 2007). Al-Makaty *et al.* (1996) asserted that the government of Saudi Arabia has to become more involved in monitoring advertising messages. The concept of justice and fairness is pertinent when developing advertisements (Rice and Al-Mossawi, 2002). Previous research on Islam and advertising do not consider the issue of advertising products without specifying what the consumer receives, such as the quantity of the product. In Islamic jurisprudence, this type of transaction is known as *Bay' Majhul*. Salafist scholars of Saudi Arabia have indicated that this type of transaction is not permissible in Islam and falls under a type of deception. Prior to transaction, the price and quantity must be made clear to the consumer. Advertising an unspecified item in the store for a certain price, such as "one of the phones on display", is considered a type of ambiguous transaction (*Gharar*). Similarly, statements that do not specify the price are ambiguous transactions. Salafist scholar, Abdul-Aziz bin Baz, stated that this is due to the Prophetic tradition:

The Prophet, peace and blessings upon him, prohibited ambiguous transactions.

Because of this, the follow consideration is made:

- C4. Companies should not engage in campaigns that defame competitors' products or participate in deceptive marketing or ambiguous marketing.

Rice and Al-Mossawi (2002) argued that deception and defamation are connected to guidance, which is a defining factor for Muslims. Salafists view deception (*Ghish*) as dishonesty and is a contradiction of Qur'anic injunctions. The Prophetic tradition on avoiding deception concerned sales and marketing (Rice and Al-Mossawi, 2002). Hanbalite jurist, Ibn Qudamah, said:

Know that deception is prohibited in sales and manufacturing [...].

The Salafist *Hanbali* jurists agreed that deception in sales and marketing are prohibited. El-Gamal (2001) noted that ambiguous transactions fall into this prohibition. Ibn Taimiah discussed the deception of ambiguous transactions extensively; however, this consideration cannot be found in the majority of the existing literature on challenges to Islamic advertising (13.5 per cent discussed this topic).

5. Implications

For the practitioner to understand the contentions of religious conservatives in Saudi Arabia toward advertising leads to effective advertising messages that do not alienate this influential segment of society. Practitioners from a non-Islamic background can learn to create inclusive advertisements for the Saudi market. Naseri and Tamam (2012) argued that advertisements are subjectively processed through affiliation to religious theology. Additionally, the study into the effect of religion and religious interpretations can contribute to present knowledge on the topic. Existing literature does not extensively investigate the differences of interpretation among notable Muslim theologies and schools of jurisprudence in relation to advertising. For instance, the conservative attitude toward the opposition of music in advertising and ambiguous transactions is rarely discussed in the current literature, leaving gaps in comprehensive studies on Islamic challenges to advertising. While religious conservatives may form a minority of the population, their influence on social attitudes is growing domestically and internationally. The current literature generalizes the challenges of Islamic advertising and marketing and overlooks the differences in schools of Islamic thought (*Madhhab*).

Based on these gaps in the literature, future studies should consider differences of opinion between the *Sunni* schools of thought. As Salafist theology and *Hanbali* jurisprudence is the most defining feature of Saudi religious society, generalizing Islamic law can alienate a significant portion of the conservatives in the market. First, identification of Islamic challenges within the different schools is needed. As religious conservatism is a growing trend in Muslim markets, addressing these challenges should be based on research into Islamic jurisprudence. Future researchers should factor the influence of Islamic scholarly opinion on consumer behavior to properly assess challenges. Practitioners may utilize the results of these types of studies to reach religious conservatives in the market. The argument could be made that generalizing Islamic challenges can reach the overall populace. However, in this case, the practitioner alienates a significant portion of the segment, especially with the growing influence of religious conservatism among younger Muslims. Furthermore, studies on religious trends among younger generations of Muslims in Saudi Arabia may contribute to the development of effective advertising messages. The considerations found in this study

do not necessitate adherence to Salafism and Hanbalism, but provide a framework to understanding Islamic challenges to advertising from the conservative interpretation.

6. Conclusion

In the past decade, religious conservatism in Islam has been increasing because of efforts of Salafist scholars in Saudi Arabia (Lacroix, 2011). Meijer (2011) noted that the influence of notable Salafist scholars like Rabee' Al-Madkhali has spread throughout Europe and America. Amghar (2007) asserted that Salafism has been on a steady rise in Europe since the 1990s. This is, in part, due to the efforts of the Saudi Government in establishing Islamic school abroad and accepting international students in Islamic universities in the Kingdom. Additionally, Amghar (2007) asserted that rise in Salafism in the Western world is due to the influence of key figures of contemporary Salafism, such as Abdul-Aziz Bin Baz, Muhammad Bin Uthaymin, Nasiruddin Al-Albani, Muqbil Al-Wadi'i, Rabi' Al-Madkhali and Salih Al-Fawzan. Even after the death of the first four scholars, their influence continues to grow among young Western Muslims (Amghar, 2007). After the Arab Spring, the influence of Salafism began to spread from Saudi Arabia to Egypt, Tunisia and Libya (Gauvain, 2010). The close relationship of Egyptian Salafists to Saudi Arabia has also been a factor that influenced the spread of Salafism. Yemeni Salafist scholar Muqbil Al-Wadi'i, a former member of the JSM who studied in Saudi Arabia, started the Salafist Dar al-Hadith school to teach Salafism. After his death, Salafism became widespread with the creation of many Salafist schools in different regions.

This study contributed to a synthesis of existing research of the Islamic attitudes toward advertising. Although Islam is not overtly opposed to advertising, there are restrictions on content and messages. Taking into consideration that Saudi Arabia is more restricted than other Muslim countries, this study investigated the attitude of religious conservatives in Saudi Arabia. The *Salafi*, or *Wahhabi*, ideology is regarded as a strictly conservative interpretation of Islamic law. Traditionally, Saudi Arabia has always been connected to Islamic clerics (*Ulema*) deriving societal attitudes based on scholarly rulings (*Fatwas*). Four considerations were derived based on existing research and religious rulings of Saudi Arabia's Salafist scholars. These considerations may be used by practitioners to avoid alienation of the conservative segment of Saudi population. Although this study has been limited to Saudi Arabia, the considerations can be extrapolated to the Salafist population outside of the Kingdom.

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